

Session 20: Plots and Subplots

Key Takeaways

- One way biblical narrative uses plot is through plot embedding, or layers of storylines working together to tell the overall story of the Bible.
- Individual narratives are framed within a larger context that gives them a meaning that transcends the individual events.
- The Hebrew Bible is about our need for the messiah, and the New Testament reveals that Jesus is the Messiah we need. Both Jesus and the apostles appeal to the Hebrew Bible to reveal Jesus' true identity.

Plots Within Plots Within Plots

The entire biblical narrative works like a complex interweaving of plot layers. Each subplot contributes to the higher level, and each higher level determines the ultimate meaning of the subplot.

Plot Level 1: God and the Nations

Genesis 1-11 sets the story in motion.

- Humans are installed as divine images to rule on God's behalf
- Humans foolishly forfeit their responsibility, and they are exiled unto the land of death
- But God promises to raise up a "seed" who will overcome evil through death
- From outside Eden to Babylon (Gen. 4-11)

Plot Level 2: God and Abraham's Family

Genesis 12 through the rest of the Hebrew Bible tells the story of God and Israel.

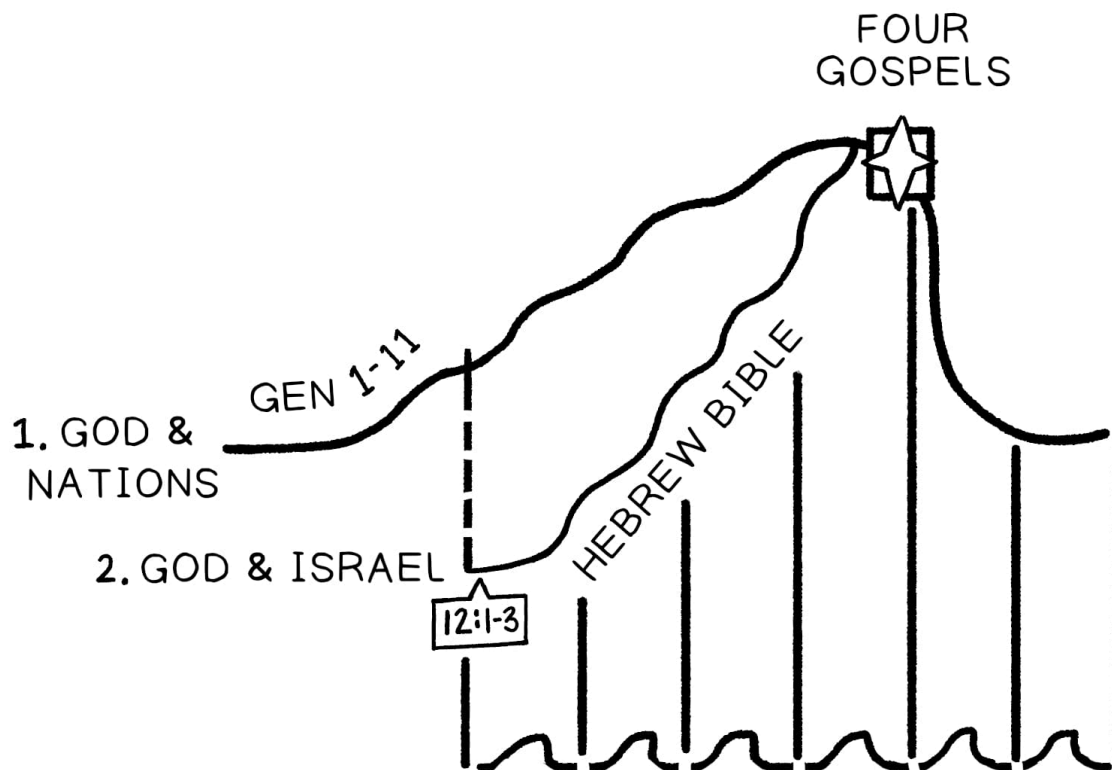
- Abraham's family and the covenant promise (Gen. 12-50)
- The exodus (Exod. 1-18)
- The covenant at Mount Sinai (Exod. 19-Num. 10)
- Wilderness wanderings (Num. 10-Deut. 34)
- Entry to the promised land (Josh.)
- The failure of the judges (Jud.)
- The failure of the monarchy (Sam.-Kgs.)
- Return from exile and unrealized hopes (Ezra-Neh.)

Plot Levels 1 and 2 Combine: Jesus and the Restoration of God's Reign

The New Testament brings together both levels of the plot of the Hebrew Bible. Jesus is both the faithful human image that rules the world with God (plot level 1) and the faithful Israelite through whom God's covenant promises can spread to the nations (plot level 2).

Plot Level 3: The Plot of Each Biblical Narrative

The plot at levels 1 and 2 is carried along by a vast number of shorter narratives, each with their own plotlines. Hundreds of individual narratives make up all of the larger movements. Every individual narrative is framed within its larger plot context. The ultimate meaning of these individual stories depends on their placement in the overall story.



The Plotline of the Bible. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

Reflection Question

How would you summarize the way that the story of Abraham's family relates to the story of the whole Hebrew Bible?